My Son Susie

By Cheryl Royce

A man speaks from the waiting room of a hospital maternity ward and reflects on his own childhood.

SEYMORE: (Pg 178) I was born on May 19, 1962, a son, to Eleanor and Buster Santacroce of Skokie, Illinois. I was perfectly normal in every way. Delivered in the manner of Julius Caesar due to the extreme size of my head and the extreme youth of the mother. She was 15 at the time.

INTRODUCTION

Both my parents loved me. I know that emphatically, down in the deepest recesses of my being. I haven't always given them the love . . . the respect they deserve . . . see, they are retarded. That's the word they used when I was growing up in the 1960's. Today the better term is "intellectually challenged."

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SEYMORE: (Pg 178-182) To say that my birth was "unplanned" is the hyperbole of understatement. Both my parents were orphans, my mother abandoned at birth in a laundry basket on the church steps. No kidding. My father was a change-of-life baby born in the 49th year of a woman already mother to eight others. She died when he was 4. Buster wended his way through the foster care system until he arrived at the same institution as my mother. It was love at first sight. Mom and Pop. Romeo and Juliet. John and Yoko. The Captain and Tenille.

Oh, did I mention that my parents are severely retarded?

Had this occurred in a secular institution, a discreet abortion would have been performed, especially in light of the fact that neither of the parents had parents and to cover the odd bureaucratic ass for its obvious lack of supervision. But it was a Catholic institution and instead, discreet nuptials were performed and the groom carried his pregnant bride over the threshold of an efficiency apartment paid for by the parish.

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Buster and Eleanor were legally married in the eyes of God and therefore entitled to all conjugal embraces, which is Catholic for . . . the hokey-pokey. Since birth control is forbidden and the rhythm method beyond a pair who counts "1, 2, 9, 17, 9 . . . "; since Eleanor had at least thirty fertile years ahead of her, and Buster, was 23, letters seeking a sterilization procedure were dispatched to the Vatican . . . [but] May 19 rolled around, and the Holy Father still had not been heard from. As Buster sat in the waiting room, amusing himself with pictures of bare-breasted African women in the National Geographics, a kindly Jewish doctor knocked Eleanor out, brought her 9 pound baby boy into the world, and without fuss or fanfare, (or anyone's permission) quietly tied her tubes. While Catholics and Jews share the same Ten Commandments, I always suspect that an Eleventh was slipped to Moses on Mt. Sinai and that is . . . Common Sense.

Eleanor came out of the ether none the worse for wear and delighted as a child to see me. Buster was overjoyed, though I suspect that some of his excitement was due to the naked ladies he had been ogling all afternoon. A few days later, the nurse enquired of my mother the name of the baby for the birth certificate. "Susie" she replied promptly and would not be dissuaded despite the calendar of saint's names proffered. Buster was consulted, but his choice of "Boy" was hardly better and rather than have me sound like something out of a Tarzan comic book, they turned again to my mother. Besides, Buster had discovered the buttons for making the hospital bed go up and down and was having too much fun to concern himself with the problem at hand. At this point, the kindly Jewish doctor intervened once more and wrote "Seymore" in the space for given name. The name he gave me was his own.

Since the Catholics don't have a "Saint Seymore" I was baptized "Savior" – close enough – and Santacroce which means "Holy Cross" and is the name of the parish church. SO it is Seymore Savior Santacroce who [is] before you. My mother, however, calls me "Susie" to this day.

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When the proud parents returned to the apartment, they did not go alone. They were accompanied by a flotilla of nurses, public health care officials, advocacy groups for the "intellectually challenged," journalists, nuns, neighborhood biddies, thrill seekers and a succession of social workers only marginally les strange than they.

I, like the Sleeping Beauty of the fable, was attended by a dozen fairy godmothers on any given day. I was coddled and cuddled. The "flotilla's" main concern was that I might not be receiving enough "stimulation." And so I was flashcarded, Montessori'ed, and Suzuki'ed within an inch of my life, any quiet time with a thumb and a blanket viewed as delinquency on the part of my nursemaids. I was like the office philodendron which everyone waters because they are afraid no one else will. It didn't hurt me though.

I grew until at the age of 5, having an intelligence higher than that of both my parents – combined – I set off for the first day of kindergarten. What a day it was! Remember your very first day of school? The pity? The terror? Papa Bear, Mama Bear, Baby Bear and our social worker, Mrs. Singh – striking out while the porridge cooled! Mrs. Singh bundled us into her Nash Rambler and off we dashed to Holy Cross Parochial School – Sister Mary's K-1 class! Wheee!

Sister Mary was young and freckled and sweet as pie. [She] shook hands politely with Mother and Father, introduced them to some of the other parents and graciously invited them to look around the room. Then she knelt down to me.

SISTER MARY: What's your name?

SEYMORE: *(shyly)* Susie *(to audience)* Sister Mary had been forewarned, but not for that.

MRS. SINGH: His name is Seymore

SEYMORE: But from the end of the room came my mother's ten decibel echolalia, "Susie, Susie, Susie, Susie, Susie, Susie, Susie!" setting everyone straight for once and all.

Then came the moment of truth: the moment when mothers and fathers and social workers tiptoe out of the room. I was a brave boy. I didn't cry or wet my pants. Buster did

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both. It was less about leaving me than leaving a toy fire engine he had been riding around the room.

Mrs. Singh tried to coax him away, but he was having none of it. Great blubbering sobs shook him. Eleanor had meanwhile retreated to the farthest corner of the playhouse and had taken up her wail of "Susie, Susie, Susie." Several children joined Buster in his blub, blub, blubbing. Eventually, they all just ran out of steam, and as kindergarten was only half-day, Mrs. Singh was able to drive us home a couple of hours later, a good time had by all. Wheeee! *(long beat)*

(Pg 183-186) Escape came on the "little cat feet" of a college education. The State defrayed all my tuition and expenses and threw in a stipend. I went away to school. My mother cried and so did my father. And he wet his pants again. I phoned them frequently at first, and while they both loved the telephone, our lopsided conversations grew harder and harder and Buster and Eleanor grew more and more remote. I made phone calls instead to their social worker, Mr. Gold, to reassure myself that they were OK. I was convinced they hardly knew I was gone and positive they didn't miss me. I didn't miss them. The sweet breezes of normalcy blew through my life for the first time.

It was spring of my freshman year. I hadn't seen Mom and Pop since Christmas. I hadn't pledged a frat but was considering it for the fall. Anyway, that's where I was on a beautiful spring night – in a frat house on Greek Row, kissing the prettiest girl in the room – when I saw the hunched back of Mr. Gold enter the room.

I can't tell you what my heart did. For close behind him were Buster and Eleanor. The room went silent. Not all at once. Voices died and conversations dropped off and someone unplugged the stereo that was blaring and the trio stopped before me. Mr. Gold explained that Eleanor had become more and more despondent when she hadn't heard from "Susie" and that Buster had been dialing his number at all hours of the day and night, hollering that it was a "mergency!" And so, at his wits' end, he had piled them into his car and driven them to see me. He was sorry, but what was he supposed to do?

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I stood like a tree stump. I could see the two of them holding hands and grinning from ear to ear behind Mr. Gold. I think Eleanor waved a little wave. And I could see my life pass before my eyes. Not my past. My future. The girl I had been kissing, the pretty one, stepped from behind me and around Mr. Gold.

KAY: You must be Seymore's parents. It's nice to meet you. My name is Kay. Seymore, why don't we take your folks outside.

SEYMORE: Which of us doesn't think their parents are retarded? Who doesn't live with them in an agony of love and shame? No one. *(long beat)*

Buster died later that year. He was 43. As you may or may not know, the retarded have a shorter life expectancy. I was home when it happened, on summer vacation. The sound that came out of Eleanor when I told her was like nothing I have heard before or since. She howled like a dog is as near as I can describe it. And she wept. Endlessly. Ceaselessly. Tirelessly. For three days. And then, I think, she forgot. *(long beat)*

[Kay's] inside now, sleeping. She just gave birth to our daughter. Six pounds, eight ounces. Susan Eleanor. *(picks up the baby from her crib and crosses to Eleanor, his mother, gently handing her the swaddled baby)* So, Mom, what do you think of your new granddaughter . . . Susie . . . That's right, Mom. *(to audience)* Perfectly normal in every way.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2001 National Qualifier
2012 National Qualifier
2015 National Qualifier
2017 National Qualifier
2021 National Qualifier
IL State Qualifier
KS State Qualifier

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